School of Pedagogical and behavioral Sciences

Department of Special Needs and Inclusive Education

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Chapter : One
Understanding Disabilities and Vulnerabilities

Outline :

- Definition of Basic Terms
- Models of Disabilities
- Causes of Disability
- Some Type of Disabilities
- Vulnerabilities

Objectives

At the end of completing this Chapter, you will be able to:

- Define basic terms : Impairment, Disability, Handicap, and Vulnerability
- Discuss Models of Disability
- Explain Brief Causes of Disability and Vulnerability
- List Different Types of Disabilities and Vulnerabilities

DEFINITION OF TERMS

Impairment:

- any loss or abnormality of psychological or anatomical structure or function.
- It can be temporary or permanent; progressive, regressive or static; intermittent or continuous.
- It could also a condition in which the body exists but doesn‘t function.

Disability:

- any restriction or lack of ability (resulting from an impairment) to perform an activity in the manner or within the range considered normal for a human being.
- A **disability exists** when an impairment limits a person’s ability to perform certain tasks Eg: inability to read, see, put on ones clothes, hear, etc…
- It can be also be defined as a functional limitation

Handicap:

- any disadvantage for a given individual, resulting from impairment or a disability that **limits or prevents the fulfilment of a role that is normal** for that individual.
- One may have an impairment which results in disability but the disability only becomes a handicap in terms of architectural, legal, social and political barriers in the environment.

➢ **So the full inclusion of people with impairments in society can be inhibited by:**

- **Attitudinal** (societal barriers, such as stigma)
- **Physical barriers** (environmental barriers, such as absence of stairs), and
- **Policy barriers** (systemic barriers),

MODELS OF DISABILITIES

Medical Model (Approach)

Disability

- functional limitations due to physical, intellectual or psychic impairment, health or psychic disorders on a person.
- has given rise to the idea that people are individual objects to be treated, changed" or improved" and made more normal.
- views the person with disability as needing to fit in rather than thinking about how society itself should change.
- does not adequately explain the interaction between societal conditions or expectations and unique circumstances of an individual.

The social Model

Disability

- largely depends on the context and is a consequence of discrimination, prejudice and exclusion.
- a highly varied and complex condition with a range of implications for social identity and behavior.
- also emphasizes the shortcomings in the environment and in many organized activities in society, for example on information, communication and education, which prevent persons with disabilities from participating on equal terms.

The two Models

Medical Model:	Social Model:
Child is faulty	Child is valued
Diagnosis and labeling	Strengths and needs identified
Impairment is focus of attention	Barriers identified and solutions developed
Segregation and alternative services	Resources made available
Re-entry if normal enough or permanent exclusion	Diversity welcomed; child is welcomed
Society remains unchanged	Society evolves

CAUSES OF DISABILITY

Disability can be caused by the following factors.

- **Genetic Causes :**
  - Abnormalities in genes and genetic inheritance
- **Environmental**
  - Poverty and malnutrition in pregnant mothers **before birth**.
  - **poverty and malnutrition after birth** can also cause poor development of vital organs in the child, which can eventually lead to disability.
  - The use of drugs, alcohol, tobacco, the exposure to certain toxic chemicals and illnesses,
  - Childhood diseases
  - **Toxic material** such as lead and mercury can damage the brain too.
  - **Unfortunate life events** such as drowning, **automobile accidents**, **falls**

- **Inaccessible Environments**
  - Sometimes society makes it difficult for people with some impairment to function freely.
  - When society develops infrastructure such as houses, roads, parks and other public places without consideration to people with impairment, the basically make it impossible for them to take care of themselves.
  - Lack of education, support services, health and opportunities for people with impairment can cause additional disability to people with disabilities and even people with no disability.
- **Unknown Causes**
  - The human body is a phenomenal thing. Scientists have still not figured out what and how some things in the **body, cells, brain, and genes** come about. Humans have still not found all the answers to all the defects in the human body.
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SOME / MAJOR TYPE OF DISABILITIES /Person with Special Needs

Visual Impairment

- has two sub- classifications.
  - **Low vision/Partially sighted :** a person is said to be low vision/partially sighted if he/she uses magnifying glasses or other adaptations to learn using his/her vision.
  - **Blindness:** refers to vision loss that is not correctable with eyeglasses or contact lenses.
    - A person is blind if he/she uses other senses like touching or auditory, other than vision, to learn and to get information.

Hearing Impairment

- has sub-classifications of the hard of hearing and deaf.

➢ **Hard of Hearing:** is a term to describe persons with enough residual hearing, to use hearing (usually with a hearing aid) as a primary modality for acquisition of language and in communication with others.

➢ **Deaf:** is a term used to describe persons whose sense of hearing is non-functional for ordinary use in communication, with or without hearing aid.

- ✓ A person is unable to understand speech even in the presence of amplification.
- ✓ Those who have difficulty understanding speech, even with hearing aids but can successfully communicate in sign language.

Specific Learning Disability

- It is a disorder in one or more of the basic psychological processes involved in understanding or in using language, spoken or written, that may manifest itself in the imperfect ability to listen, think, speak, read, write, spell, or to do mathematical calculations.

Specific Types of Learning Disabilities /Auditory Processing Disorder

- ✓ **Dyscalculia:** is a specific learning disability that affects a person‘s ability to understand numbers and learn math.
- ✓ **Dysgraphia :** is a specific learning disability that affects a person‘s handwriting ability and fine motor skills.
- ✓ **Dyslexia :** is a specific learning disability that affects reading and related language-based processing skills.

- **Language Processing Disorder:** a specific type of Auditory Processing Disorder in which there is difficulty attaching meaning to sound groups that form words, sentences and stories.
- **Non-Verbal Learning Disabilities:** a disorder which is usually characterized by a significant discrepancy between higher verbal skills and weaker motor, visual-spatial and social skills.
- **Visual Perceptual/Visual Motor Deficit:** a disorder that affects the understanding of information that a person sees, or the ability to draw or copy.

Speech and Language Impairments /Communication Disorder

- **Communication** is the process of an exchanging knowledge, idea, opinion and feeling. it requires encoding (sending in understandable form)and decoding (receiving and understanding messages).
- Speech and Language are tools used for communication.
- **It has two sub classifications:**

1. Speech Impairments : an impairment of voice, articulation of speech sounds, or fluency.

A. Voice disorders : problems with the quality or use of one's voice resulting from disorders in the larynx.

✓ characterized by abnormal production and/or absences of vocal quality, pitch, loudness, and/or duration.

B. Articulation disorders: errors in the production of speech sounds that may be related to anatomical or physiological limitations in the skeletal, muscular, or neuromuscular support for speech production.

- ✓ **These disorders include**:

  Omissions: (bo for boat) =

  Substitutions: (wabbit for rabbit) =

  Distortions: (shlip for sip)

C. Fluency disorders : difficulties with the rhythm and timing of speech characterized by hesitations, repetitions, or prolongations of sounds, syllables, words, or phrases. Common fluency disorders include:

- ✓ **Stuttering:** rapid-fire repetitions of consonant or vowel sounds especially at the beginning of words, prolongations, hesitations, interjections, and complete verbal blocks.
- ✓ **Cluttering:** excessively fast and jerky speech

2.Language Impairments : the impairment or deviant development of comprehension and use of spoken, written, or other symbol systems. There are five basic areas of language impairments:

- ✓ **Phonological disorders :** the abnormal organization of the phonological system, or a significant deficit in speech production or perception.
- ✓ **Morphological disorders :** difficulties with morphological inflections (inflections on nouns, verbs, and adjectives that signal different kinds of meanings).
- ✓ **Semantic disorders :** poor vocabulary development, inappropriate use of word meanings, and/or inability to comprehend word meanings.
- ✓ **Syntactic deficits :** difficulty in acquiring the rules that govern word order and others aspects of grammar such as subject-verb agreement.
- ✓ **Pragmatic difficulties :** problems in understanding and using language in different social contexts.

Autism

- a developmental disability significantly affecting verbal and nonverbal communication and social interaction, generally evident before age three that adversely affects a child‘s educational performance.
- a neurodevelopment disorder defined by impairments in social and communication development, accompanied by stereotyped patterns of behavior and interest
- pervasive developmental disorder characterized by lack of normal sociability, impaired communication and repetitive obsessive behavior
- characteristics often associated with engaging in repetitive activities and stereotyped movements, resistance to environmental change or change in daily routines, and unusual responses to sensory experiences.

Emotional and Behavioral Disorders

- a condition exhibiting one or more of the following characteristics over a long period of time
  - ✓ An inability to learn that cannot be explained by intellectual, sensory, or health factors;
  - ✓ An inability to build or maintain satisfactory interpersonal relationships with peers and teachers;
  - ✓ Inappropriate types of behavior or feelings under normal circumstances;
  - ✓ A general pervasive mood of unhappiness or depression; or
  - ✓ A tendency to develop physical symptoms or fears associated with personal or school problems.

Classification of Behavioral and Emotional Disorders

- **Conduct disorder:** individuals may seek attention, are disruptive and act out. The disorder is classified by type: overt (with violence or tantrums) versus covert (with lying, stealing, and/or drug use).
- **Socialized aggression:** individuals join subculture group of peers who are openly disrespectful to their peers, teachers, and parents.
- **Attention problems-** These individuals may have attention deficit, are easily destructible and have poor concentration.
- **Anxiety/Withdrawn-** These individuals are self-conscious, reserved, and unsure of themselves. They typically have low self-esteem and withdraw from immediate activities.
- **Psychotic behavior:** These individuals show more bizarre behavior. They may hallucinate, deal in a fantasy world and may even talk in gibberish.
- **Motor excess:** These people are hyperactive. They cannot sit nor listen to others nor keep their attention focused.

Kauffman (1993) conclude that emotion or behavioral disorders fall into two broad classifications:

- **Externalizing Behavior**: under controlled disorder, include such problems disobedience, disruptiveness, fighting, tempers tantrums, irresponsibility, jealous, anger, attention seeking etc…
- **Internalizing Behavior**: over controlled disorders, include such problems anxiety, immaturity, shyness, social withdrawal, feeling of inadequacy (inferiority), guilt, depression and worries a great deal

Causes of emotional and behavioral disorders

- EBD result from many causes such as:
  - ✓ **Biological-** includes genetic disorders, brain damage, and malnutrition, allergies, temperament and damage to the central nervous system.
  - ✓ **Family factors-** include family interactions, family influence, child abuse, neglect, and poor disciplinary practices at home.
  - ✓ **Cultural factors-** include some traditional and cultural negative practices, for example watching violence and sexually oriented movies and TV programs.
  - ✓ **Environmental factors-** include peer pressure, living in impoverished areas, and schooling practices that are unresponsive to individual needs.

Intellectual Disability

- A disability characterized by significant limitations in both intellectual functioning and in adaptive behavior, which covers many everyday social and practical skills.
- An individual is considered to have an intellectual disability based on the following three criteria:
  - ✓ **Sub average intellectual functioning:** refers to general mental capacity, such as learning, reasoning, problem solving, and so on.
  - ✓ **Significant limitations exist in two or more adaptive skill areas:** the collection of conceptual, social, and practical skills that are learned and performed by people in their everyday lives.
  - ✓ **Manifestation during developmental period :** states that intellectual disability must manifest before the age of 18. Thus, the disability must have arisen sometime between conception and adulthood.

Developmental Characteristics of CWIDs

Motivation:

- described as lacking motivation, or outer-directed behavior. Past experiences of failure and the anxiety generated by those failures may make them appear to be fewer goals directed and lacking in motivation.

Academic Achievement:

- The cognitive difficulties of children with mild to moderate intellectual disabilities lead to persistent problems in academic achievement unless intensive and extensive supports are provided.

Physical characteristics:

- Children with intellectual disabilities with differing biological etiologies, may exhibit coexisting problems, such as physical, motor, orthopedic, visual and auditory impairments, and health problems.

Classification of intellectual disability by levels of support:

Levels and areas of support for intellectual disabilities				
Level of support	Duration of support	Frequency of support	Setting of support	Amount of professional assistance
Intermittent	Only as needed	Occasional or infrequent	Usually only one or two (e.g.1–2 classes or activities)	Occasional consultation or monitoring by professional
Limited	As needed, but sometimes continuing	Regular, but frequency varies	Several settings, but not usually all	Occasional or regular contact with professionals
Extensive	Usually continuing	Regular, but frequency varies	Several settings, but not usually all	Regular contact with professionals at least once a week
Pervasive	May be lifelong	Frequent or continuous	Nearly all settings	Continuous contact and monitoring by professionals

Physical disability/Orthopedic Impairment and Health impairment

- **Physical disability :** a condition that interferes with the individual‘s ability to use his or her body. Many but not all, physical disabilities are orthopedic impairments. (The term orthopedic impairment generally refers to conditions of muscular or skeletal system and sometimes to physical disabling conditions of the nervous system).

- **Health impairment** : a condition that requires ongoing medical attention. It includes asthma, heart defects, cancer, diabetes, hemophilia. HIV/AIDS, etc.

Physical /Orthopedic Impairment

Classification and Characteristics:

- based on the impact of physical disability on mobility and motor skills, it is divided into three.

A. **Mild physical disability:** these individuals are able to walk without aids and may make normal developmental progress.

B. **Moderate physical disability:** individuals can walk with braces and crutches and may have difficulty with fine-motor skills and speech production.

C. **Severe physical disability:** these are individuals who are wheel-chair dependent and may need special help to achieve regular development.

On the other hand the physical/orthopedic impairment could be broadly classified in to two:

- The neurological system (the brain, spinal cord & nerve) related problems.
- Musculo skeletal system (the muscles, bones and joints) are deficient due to various

I. The Neurological System

- ✓ **Epilepsy:** disorder that occurs when the brain cells are not working properly and is often called a seizure disorder.
- ✓ **Spinal bifida and spinal cord injury:-** damage to the spinal cord leads to paralysis and loss of sensation in the affected areas of the body and it is a birth defect of the backbone (spinal column). The cause is unknown but it usually occurs in the first twenty-six days of pregnancy.

II. Musculo skeletal System

- The list of the impairment and associated with musculoskeletal malformation are the following:
  - ✓ **Muscular dystrophy:** an inherited condition accruing mainly in males, in which the muscles weaken and deteriorate.
  - ✓ **Arthritis:** an inflammation of the joints. Symptoms include swollen and stiff joints, fever, and pain in the joints during acute periods.
  - ✓ **Amputation:** a small number of children have missing limbs because of congenital abnormalities or injury or disease (malignant bone tumors in the limbs).

Other muscle-skeletal disorders are:

- ✓ **Marfan syndrome:** a genetic disorder in which the muscles are poorly developed and the spine is curved. Individuals with marfan syndrome may have either long, thin limbs, prominent shoulder blades, spinal curvature, flat feet, or long fingers & thumbs.
- ✓ **Achondroplasis:** a genetic disorder. Children with this disorder usually develop a normal torso but have a straight upper back and a curved lower back (sway back).
  - These children are at risk of sudden death during sleep from compression of the spinal cord interfering with their breathing

- **Polio:-** is viral disease that invade the brain and cause severe paralysis of the total body system.
- **Club foot:-** is a major orthopedic problem affecting infants each year. This term is used to describe various ankle or foot deformities.
- **Cleft lip and cleft palate:-** are openings in the lip or roof of the mouth, respectively, that fail to close before birth, the cause is unknown. Most cleft problems can be repaired through surgery.

Health Impairments

- Any disease that interferes with learning can make students eligible for special services.
- These disease caused problems are as follow.
  - ✓ **Heart disease**: common among young people. It is caused by improper circulation of blood by the heart some of the disorders are congenital)present at birth); others are the product of inflammatory heart disease.
  - ✓ **Cystic fibrosis :** a hereditary disease that affects the lungs and pancreas. It leads to recurrent respiratory and digestive problems including abnormal amounts of thick mucus, sweet and saliva.
  - ✓ **Acquired immune deficiency syndrome** (AIDS): a very severe disease caused by human immunodeficiency virus (HIV).
  - ✓ **Hemophilia**: a hereditary disease in which the blood clots very slowly or not all. The disorder is transmitted by sex-linked recessive gene and nearly always occurs in males.
  - ✓ **Asthma**: is a chronic respiratory condition characterized by repeated breathing difficulties especially while exhaling.
  - ✓ **Diabetes**: Developmental or hereditary disorder characterized by inadequate secretion or use of insulin .

- ✓ **Nephrosis & Nephritis :** Kidney disorders or diseases caused by infections, poisoning, burns, accidents or other diseases
- ✓ **Sickle-cell anemia:** Hereditary and chronic blood disease characterized by red blood cells that are distorted and that do not circulate properly
- ✓ **Leukemia:** Disease characterized by excessive production of white blood Cells
- ✓ **Lead poisoning:** Disorder caused by ingesting lead-based paint chips or other substances containing lead
- ✓ **Rheumatic fever:** Disease characterized by painful swelling and inflammation of the joints that can spread to the ear and central nervous system.
- ✓ **Tuberculosis :** Infectious disease that commonly affects the lungs and may affect other tissues of the body.
- ✓ **Cancer** Abnormal growth of cells that can affect any organ system

VULNERABILITY

- means being at risk of being harmed.
- Everyone can be harmed, so being vulnerable is part of being human. In principle, everyone is vulnerable to some adverse event or circumstance, but some people are more vulnerable than others.
- vulnerability can be generally defined as a complex phenomenon that refers to the following dimensions:

✓ **A. Economic difficulties/lack of financial resources:** poverty, low living standards, housing problems (e.g. too damp, too expensive, too cold or difficult to heat) etc.;

✓ **B. Social exclusion:** limited access to facilities such as transportations, schools, libraries or medical services;

- **C. Lack of social support from social networks:** no assistance from family members, friends, neighbors or colleagues (referring to practical help as well as emotional support) like highly gifted individuals;

- **D. Stigmatization:** being a victim of stereotypes, being devalued, confronted with disgraceful behavior because of belonging to a particular social or ethnic group;

- **E. Health difficulties:** disadvantages resulting from poor mental health, physical health or disabilities;

- **F. Being a victim of crime:** in family context especially of violence.

Causes of Vulnerability

Vulnerability may be causes by :

- ✓ rapid population growth,
- ✓ poverty and hunger,
- ✓ poor health,
- ✓ low levels of education,
- ✓ gender inequality,
- ✓ fragile and hazardous location,
- ✓ lack of access to resources and services,
- ✓ disintegration of social patterns (social vulnerability)
- ✓ lack of access to information and knowledge,
- ✓ lack of public awareness,
- ✓ limited access to political power and representation (political vulnerability),

Characteristics of Vulnerable People

- ✓ Less physically or mentally capable (infants, older adults, people with disabilities)
- ✓ Fewer material and/or financial resources (low-income households, homeless)
- ✓ Less knowledge or experience (children, illiterate, foreigners, tourists)
- ✓ Restricted by society to grow and develop according to their needs and potentials

➢ People who are helped by others (who are then restricted by commitments) are still vulnerable people, which includes the following extracted from various researches.

- ✓ **Women (**particularly women in developing nations and those who are living in rural areas)
- ✓ **Children (**illegally working children, children who are pregnant or become mothers, children born out of marriage, children from a single-parent, delinquent children, homeless children, HIV infected children, uneducated children, institutionalized children, married children, mentally ill children, migrant children, orphans, sexually exploited children, street children, war-affected children…etc.

- ✓ Minorities (people are vulnerable due to their minority background)
- ✓ Poverty (poor person)
- ✓ Person with Disabilities
- ✓ Old people or very young children
- ✓ People with high rates of illiteracy and lack quality educational opportunities
- ✓ Sickness (Uncured health problems)
- ✓ Gifted and Talentedness

THANK YOU IN ADVANCE FOR YOUR DUE ATTENTION